



Cigars and Tall Stories

Cigar smokers on the dias for the Elmira Baseball banquet at Samuel Clemens' hostelry were numerous and gave to the smoothly-operated occasion an air of affluence by the Philadelphia Phillies organization. You'd think they were advertising the stogie of the same name, or just advertising money. Even Manager Eddie Sawyer said that his boss, Bob Carpenter, has a few million dollars, "more than Benny Bengough, Andy Seminick and I made together last year." One of the cigar smokers not on the platform was Andy Cohen, a former Elmira Pioneers' infielder, ex-manager of Denver, now enjoying a civil life.

Andy was telling about the era when he first played at Dunn Field. Andy had one fan. Everytime he went up to the plate, this fan would holler, "Put the wood to it, Andy, old boy!" Cohen said he usually struck out or popped up. But this one rooter was faithful. Everytime Andy came to bat, he would yell, "Put the old wood to it Andy, old boy!" This one time, Andy said, he saw the pitch coming straight for his head. "I ducked, but not soon enough. The ball hit me in the head, and bounced out into the infield." The man up in the stands yelled, "That's putting the wood to it, Andy, old boy!" Andy added: "He was a real fan. I wound up marrying his daughter."

The stories rolled out of Bengough as fast as he could breathe. The New York Yankee catcher who preceded Bill Dickey, Benny said he broke into baseball before they had fences around the outfield, and "the grass was so high out there, the outfielders used to hide extra balls." That way, he said, the fielders could pick up any ball and throw a runner out at a base or at home. One time, out in Joplin, Mo., of the Western Association, he said, in trying to get a runner going home, an outfielder picked up, instead of a ball, a rabbit and threw it home. "Yer out!" cried the umpire. The runner yelled, "Whadda ya mean—out? He's got a rabbit, not the ball." "Okay, so you're out by a hare!"

He told about the time Dizzy Dean was pitching for Houston and in this game Diz was fortunate enough to hit a home run. But a little later Dizzy got in trouble and walked the bases loaded. The manager, thereupon, lifted Dean for another pitcher. Muffed, Dizzy, walked out to the scoreboard and took off a score of an earlier inning. "What the devil you doing?" cried the manager. Dizzy said, "If I'm not good enough to play, you can't have my run." The grass might have been tall, but Benny's tales were taller.

Sawyer admitted it was tough to follow Bengough on a program. But he wanted to illustrate the aggressiveness of the Pioneers' new manager, Andy Seminick. One day when the Phils were playing the Giants, he said, Andy "declared war" on Manager Leo Durocher's club. In running bases Seminick in succession put Bill Rigney and Eddie Stanky out of action and "the Giants were running out of infielders." The next time around Andy and the ball met Henry Thomson at third base at the same time. Thomson flew in the air and came down, out cold. Durocher partially revived Thomson and walked him around and asked him, "Do you want to play any more, Henry?" No answer. Durocher repeated, "Do you want to play any more, Henry?" Thomson finally came to. "Yes, suh, but not today." The fortunes of war and baseball are unique. The last time this corner saw Sawyer he was conducting a baseball clinic at Ithaca College and on the program was one of his staff, Danny Murtaugh. Today, Sawyer and Murtaugh are rival National League managers.